

Signorini's Problem

Max Stuthmann

February 22, 2026

Contents

1	Introduction	2
2	Mathematical Framework	3
2.1	Scalars, Vectors and Matrices	3
2.2	L^p -Spaces	3
2.3	Test Functions & Distributional Derivatives	5
2.4	Regular Distributions & Weak Derivatives	8
2.5	Sobolev Spaces	8
2.6	Trace Operators & Boundary Spaces	8
2.7	Distributional Derivatives	8
2.8	Sobolev Spaces	11
3	Signorini's Problem	13
3.1	Physical and Geometric Setup of the Problem	13
3.2	Weak Formulation	14
3.2.1	Admissible Displacements	14
3.2.2	Small Strain Elasticity	14
3.2.3	Energy Minimization and Well-posedness	16
3.2.4	Variational inequality as an optimality condition	19
3.3	Strong Formulation	22
3.3.1	Stress Regularity and Boundary Tractions	22
3.3.2	A Hybrid Formulation	23
3.3.3	Normal/Tangential Splitting and Contact Trace Spaces	25
3.3.4	KKT Contact Conditions	25
3.3.5	Classical Strong Form under Additional Regularity	25
3.4	Mixed Formulation	25
3.4.1	Mixed Weak Formulation as a Saddlepoint Problem	25
3.4.2	Well-posedness and inf-sup condition	25
4	Outlook	26
A	References	I
B	List of Figures	I

Abstract

This is the abstract.[1]

1 Introduction

This is the Introduction.

2 Mathematical Framework

This section introduces the basic notation used throughout the mathematical framework and the later analysis of Signorini's problem. Our goal is to fix a consistent language for bulk quantities, boundary quantities, and tensor-valued fields before introducing weak derivatives and Sobolev spaces. Unless stated otherwise, let $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$, $d \geq 1$, be a nonempty open set. Whenever trace operators or boundary spaces are used, we additionally assume that Ω is a bounded Lipschitz domain (see e.g. [1, Section 2.3]) and write $\Gamma := \partial\Omega$.

2.1 Scalars, Vectors and Matrices

The purpose of this subsection is mainly to introduce the notation used throughout this report. For $m, n \geq 1$, we write $\mathbb{R}^{m \times n}$ for the space of real $m \times n$ matrices and for vectors $u, v \in \mathbb{R}^m$, we denote by

$$u \cdot v := \sum_{j=1}^m u_j v_j, \quad |u| := \sqrt{u \cdot u}$$

the Euclidean inner product and norm. For matrices $A, B \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times n}$, we use the Frobenius product

$$A : B := \sum_{j=1}^m \sum_{k=1}^n A_{jk} B_{jk}, \quad |A| := \sqrt{A : A}.$$

The space $\text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$ of symmetric second order tensors is

$$\text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d) := \left\{ s \in \mathbb{R}^d \otimes \mathbb{R}^d \mid s^\top = s \right\}.$$

We will interpret these tensors as symmetric matrices in $\mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ in the canonical basis of $\mathbb{R}^d$. Indeed,

$$\text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d) \cong \left\{ S \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d} \mid S^\top = S \right\}.$$

Furthermore, if $\mathcal{A} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathcal{L}(\text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d); \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ is a fourth order tensor and $s \in \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$, we use the *double contraction*

$$(\mathcal{A}(x) : s)_{ij} := \sum_{k=1}^d \sum_{l=1}^d \mathcal{A}_{ijkl}(x) s_{kl}, \quad s : \mathcal{A}(x) : s := \sum_{i=1}^d \sum_{j=1}^d \sum_{k=1}^d \sum_{l=1}^d \mathcal{A}_{ijkl}(x) s_{ij} s_{kl}.$$

2.2 L^p -Spaces

Even assuming the reader is already familiar with the concept of L^p -spaces, the definitions and notations are listed below. We begin with the L^p -spaces on Ω as spaces of equivalence classes of p -integrable functions whose difference vanishes almost everywhere on Ω . Although this is the most correct way to define L^p -spaces, we will subsequently always assume an actual function by choosing an arbitrary representative of a class. The assumed measure on Ω here is the Lebesgue measure in $\mathbb{R}^d$. We omit the case $p = \infty$.

Definition 2.1 (L^p -Spaces). *Let $m \geq 1$ and $1 \leq p < \infty$. We define*

$$L^p(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \left\{ u : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m \text{ measurable} \mid \int_{\Omega} |u|^p \, dx < \infty \right\} / \sim,$$

where $u \sim v$ if and only if $u = v$ almost everywhere in Ω . For some equivalence class $[u] \in L^p(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ we take an arbitrary representative and write $u = [u]$. If $m = 1$, we abbreviate $L^p(\Omega) := L^p(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^1)$ and note that

$$L^p(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) = (L^p(\Omega))^m, \quad \forall m \geq 1.$$

Next, it is necessary to define these spaces for boundary parts of Ω as well. This is done analogously, with the difference that we now consider a surface or boundary integral and accordingly also the Lebesgue measure on $\mathbb{R}^{d-1}$.

Definition 2.2 (*L^p -Spaces on Boundary Parts*). Assume that Ω is a bounded Lipschitz domain and let $\Gamma_0 \subset \Gamma$ be measurable with respect to the surface measure on Γ . For $m \geq 1$ and $1 \leq p < \infty$, we define

$$L^p(\Gamma_0; \mathbb{R}^m) := \left\{ g : \Gamma_0 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m \text{ measurable} \mid \int_{\Gamma_0} |g|^p \, ds < \infty \right\} / \sim,$$

where $g \sim h$ if and only if $g = h$ almost everywhere on Γ_0 . For some equivalence class $[g] \in L^p(\Gamma_0; \mathbb{R}^m)$ we take an arbitrary representative and write $g = [g]$. If $m = 1$, we abbreviate $L^p(\Gamma_0) := L^p(\Gamma_0; \mathbb{R}^1)$ and note that

$$L^p(\Gamma_0; \mathbb{R}^m) = (L^p(\Gamma_0))^m, \quad \forall m \geq 1.$$

Moreover, we also need an L^2 -notation for matrix-valued fields $A : \Omega \rightarrow \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$.

Definition 2.3 (*L^p -Spaces for Matrix-Valued Fields*). Let $1 \leq p < \infty$. We define

$$L^p(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)) := \left\{ A : \Omega \rightarrow \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d) \text{ measurable} \mid \int_{\Omega} |A|^p \, dx < \infty \right\} / \sim,$$

where $A \sim B$ if and only if $A = B$ almost everywhere on Ω . For some equivalence class $[A] \in L^p(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$, we take an arbitrary representative and write $A = [A]$.

Finally, one particular L^p -space is of special interest because it is the only one that, together with its classical inner product, defines a Hilbert space. This is the case $p = 2$. We record this fact in the following proposition and simultaneously introduce a meaningful notation for its inner product and its norm.

Proposition 2.1 (*L^2 is a Hilbert Space*). For every $m \geq 1$, the space $L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is a Hilbert space with inner product

$$(u, v)_{0,\Omega} := \int_{\Omega} u \cdot v \, dx \quad u, v \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m),$$

and induced norm

$$\|u\|_{0,\Omega} := \sqrt{(u, u)_{0,\Omega}}.$$

If Ω is a bounded Lipschitz domain and $\Gamma_0 \subset \Gamma$ is measurable, $L^2(\Gamma_0; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is a Hilbert space and for $g, h \in L^2(\Gamma_0; \mathbb{R}^m)$ we analogously write

$$(g, h)_{0,\Gamma_0} := \int_{\Gamma_0} g \cdot h \, ds, \quad \|g\|_{0,\Gamma_0} := \sqrt{(g, g)_{0,\Gamma_0}}$$

Moreover, $L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ together with the inner product

$$(A, B)_{0,\Omega} := \int_{\Omega} A : B \, dx, \quad A, B \in L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$$

is a Hilbert space and the induced norm is

$$\|A\|_{0,\Omega} := \sqrt{(A, A)_{0,\Omega}}.$$

For later purpose, we also need to consider the subspace of locally integrable functions on Ω .

Definition 2.4 (Locally Integrable Functions). *The space of locally integrable functions on Ω is defined as*

$$L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \left\{ u : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m \text{ measurable} \mid |u|_K \in L^1(K; \mathbb{R}^m) \forall K \subset \Omega, K \text{ compact} \right\}.$$

For $m = 1$, we denote $L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega) := L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^1)$ and endow $L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ as well $L^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ with the norm

$$\|u\|_{L^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)} := \int_{\Omega} |u| \, dx, \quad u \in L^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m).$$

The space $L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ is defined analogously.

2.3 Test Functions & Distributional Derivatives

Before introducing Sobolev spaces, we first formalize a weak notion of differentiation. The reason is that the functions arising in variational formulations of boundary value problems are typically not smooth enough to admit classical derivatives in the pointwise sense. Nevertheless, one still wants to differentiate such functions in a meaningful way, at least under an integral sign. The key observation is that in integration by parts, derivatives can be shifted from an unknown function to a smooth test function with compact support. This suggests defining derivatives indirectly through their action on test functions. The resulting objects are distributions, and distributional derivatives extend classical derivatives whenever the latter exist. For the sake of completeness, we begin with the definitions of the classic notions of differentiation, which should already be familiar to the reader.

Definition 2.5 (Partial Derivative, Gradient, Jacobian and Divergence). *Let $u : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ and $F : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$ and $A : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}$ be sufficiently regular maps.*

i) *The partial derivative of u with respect to $\alpha \in \mathbb{N}_0^d$ is*

$$D^\alpha u := \frac{\partial^{|\alpha|} u}{\partial x_1^{\alpha_1} \dots \partial x_d^{\alpha_d}} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}.$$

ii) *The gradient of u is*

$$\nabla u := \left(\frac{\partial u}{\partial x_1}, \dots, \frac{\partial u}{\partial x_d} \right)^\top : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d.$$

iii) *The Jacobian of $F = (F_1, \dots, F_m)^\top$ is*

$$DF := \left(\frac{\partial F_j}{\partial x_k} \right)_{1 \leq j \leq m}^{1 \leq k \leq d} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}.$$

iv) *For $m = d$, the divergence of $F = (F_1, \dots, F_d)^\top$ is*

$$\text{div } F := \sum_{j=1}^d \frac{\partial F_j}{\partial x_j} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}.$$

v) *The divergence of $A = (A_{jk})_{1 \leq j \leq m}^{1 \leq k \leq d}$ is*

$$\text{div } A := \left(\sum_{k=1}^d \frac{\partial A_{jk}}{\partial x_k} \right)_{1 \leq j \leq m} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m.$$

We collect continuous functions with continuous partial derivatives of the same order in the following well-known function spaces.

Definition 2.6 (Spaces of Continuously Differentiable Functions). *We denote by $\mathcal{C}^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ the space of continuous functions $u : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$ and by*

$$\mathcal{C}^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \left\{ u \in \mathcal{C}^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \mid |\alpha| \leq k \Rightarrow D^\alpha u \in \mathcal{C}^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \right\}, \quad k \geq 0,$$

the space of such functions that are continuously differentiable up to order $k \geq 0$. Moreover,

$$\mathcal{C}^\infty(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \bigcap_{k \geq 0} \mathcal{C}^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$$

denotes the space of infinitely continuously differentiable functions. For $m = 1$, we abbreviate

$$\mathcal{C}^k(\Omega) := \mathcal{C}^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^1), \quad \forall 0 \leq k \leq \infty$$

and note that

$$\mathcal{C}^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) = (\mathcal{C}^k(\Omega))^m, \quad \forall 0 \leq k \leq \infty, m \geq 1.$$

Finally, for $0 \leq k \leq \infty$, we define

$$\mathcal{C}^k(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)) := \left\{ A = (A_{ij})_{i,j=1}^d : \Omega \rightarrow \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d) \mid A_{ij} \in \mathcal{C}^k(\Omega) \forall 1 \leq i, j \leq d \right\}.$$

A particular subspace of the $k = \infty$ case is of special interest to us and the concept of distributional derivatives. This is the space of infinitely often continuously differentiable functions with compact support, also called *test functions*.

Definition 2.7 (Test Function). *The space $\mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ contains all infinitely often continuously differentiable functions with compact support in Ω , i.e.*

$$\mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) = \{ \varphi \in \mathcal{C}^\infty(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \mid \text{supp}(\varphi) \subset \Omega \text{ compact} \}$$

For $m = 1$, we abbreviate $\mathcal{D}(\Omega) := \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^1)$ and note that

$$\mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) = (\mathcal{D}(\Omega))^m, \quad \forall m \geq 1.$$

*The space $\mathcal{D}(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ is defined analogously and functions of these spaces are called **test functions**.*

The space of test functions allows us to encode differentiation through integration by parts. This leads to distributions, which extend classical derivatives to nonsmooth functions and, more generally, to generalized functions.

Definition 2.8 (Distributions). *The space of scalar-valued distributions on Ω is the topological dual space*

$$\mathcal{D}'(\Omega) := (\mathcal{D}(\Omega))'.$$

Thus, a scalar-valued distribution is a linear continuous functional $T : \mathcal{D}(\Omega) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. For $T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ and $\varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega)$, we denote the duality pairing by $\langle T, \varphi \rangle$. For $m \geq 1$, we define the space of vector-valued distributions componentwise by

$$\mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := (\mathcal{D}'(\Omega))^m.$$

For $T = (T_1, \dots, T_m) \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ and $\varphi = (\varphi_1, \dots, \varphi_m) \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$, we use the duality

pairing

$$\langle T, \varphi \rangle := \sum_{j=1}^m \langle T_j, \varphi_j \rangle.$$

Analogously, the space $\mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ is defined componentwise, and for

$$T = (T_{jk})_{j,k=1}^d \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)), \quad \varphi = (\varphi_{jk})_{j,k=1}^d \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)),$$

we use the duality pairing

$$\langle T, \varphi \rangle := \sum_{j=1}^d \sum_{k=1}^d \langle T_{jk}, \varphi_{jk} \rangle.$$

Definition 2.9 (Distributional Derivative). *Let $T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ and $\alpha \in \mathbb{N}_0^d$. The distributional derivative $D^\alpha T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ is defined by*

$$\langle D^\alpha T, \varphi \rangle := (-1)^{|\alpha|} \langle T, D^\alpha \varphi \rangle, \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega).$$

Distributional derivatives of vector-valued and matrix-valued distributions are defined componentwise. In particular, for $T = (T_1, \dots, T_m) \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$, we define

$$D^\alpha T := (D^\alpha T_1, \dots, D^\alpha T_m) \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m).$$

Analogously, for $T = (T_{jk})_{j,k=1}^d \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$, we define

$$D^\alpha T := (D^\alpha T_{jk})_{j,k=1}^d \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)).$$

Using the componentwise definition of distributional derivatives, we can now extend the classical differential operators introduced above to distributions. For $1 \leq k \leq d$, let $e_k \in \mathbb{N}_0^d$ denote the k -th unit multi-index, i.e.

$$e_k := (0, \dots, 0, 1, 0, \dots, 0)^\top,$$

where the entry 1 is in the k -th position. Then D^{e_k} in the distributional sense coincides with ∂_{x_k} in the classical sense.

Definition 2.10 (Distributional Gradient, Jacobian and Divergence). *Let $T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ and $U \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ and $\Sigma \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$.*

i) The distributional gradient of T is

$$\nabla T := (D^{e_1} T, \dots, D^{e_d} T)^\top \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

ii) The distributional Jacobian of $U = (U_1, \dots, U_m)^\top$ is

$$DU := (D^{e_k} U_j)_{1 \leq j \leq m}^{1 \leq k \leq d} \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}).$$

iii) For $d = m$, the distributional divergence of $U = (U_1, \dots, U_d)^\top$ is

$$\text{div } U := \sum_{k=1}^d D^{e_k} U_k \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega).$$

iv) The distributional divergence of $\Sigma = (\Sigma_{jk})_{j,k=1}^d$ is

$$\text{div } \Sigma := \left(\sum_{k=1}^d D^{e_k} \Sigma_{jk} \right)_{1 \leq j \leq d} \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

At this stage, the above definitions are purely distributional and do not require any pointwise differentiability. In a later subsection, we will identify locally integrable functions with regular distributions and show that weak derivatives are precisely those distributional derivatives that are again induced by functions.

2.4 Regular Distributions & Weak Derivatives

The distributional framework introduced above becomes particularly useful once distributions are induced by locally integrable functions. These so-called regular distributions provide the link between generalized differentiation and the weak derivatives used later in Sobolev spaces and variational formulations.

Definition 2.11 (Regular Distributions). *A regular distribution is a distribution induced by a locally integrable function in the following way.*

i) For $u \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega)$, a regular distribution $T_u \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ is of the form

$$\langle T_u, \varphi \rangle := \int_{\Omega} u \varphi \, dx \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega).$$

ii) For $F \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$, a regular distribution $T_F \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is of the form

$$\langle T_F, \varphi \rangle := \int_{\Omega} F \cdot \varphi \, dx \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

iii) For $A \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$, a regular distribution $T_A \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ is of the form

$$\langle T_A, \varphi \rangle := \int_{\Omega} A : \varphi \, dx \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)).$$

In particular, locally integrable functions are embedded into the spaces of distributions, i.e. the mappings

$$f \mapsto T_f, \quad \begin{cases} f \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega) \\ f \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \\ f \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)) \end{cases}$$

are injective and their images are the spaces of regular distributions.

Proposition 2.2 (Compatibility with Classical Derivatives). *Let $u \in \mathcal{C}^{|\alpha|}(\Omega)$ and $\alpha \in \mathbb{N}_0^d$. Then*

$$D^\alpha T_u = T_{D^\alpha u} \quad \text{in } \mathcal{D}'(\Omega).$$

Analogous statements hold componentwise for vector-valued and matrix-valued functions.

2.5 Sobolev Spaces

2.6 Trace Operators & Boundary Spaces

2.7 Distributional Derivatives

In the following let $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$, $d \geq 1$ denote a Lebesgue measurable open set with non-empty interior and let $m \geq 1$. For the sake of completeness, we begin with the definitions of the classic derivation terms, which should already be familiar to the reader.

Definition 2.12 (Partial Derivative, Gradient, Jacobian and Divergence). *Let $f : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ and $F : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$ be sufficiently regular maps.*

i) *The partial derivative of f with respect to $\alpha \in \mathbb{N}_0^d$ is*

$$D^\alpha f := \frac{\partial^{|\alpha|} f}{\partial x_1^{\alpha_1} \dots \partial x_d^{\alpha_d}} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}.$$

ii) *The gradient of u is*

$$\nabla f := \left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_1}, \dots, \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_d} \right)^\top : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d.$$

iii) *The Jacobian of $F = (F_1, \dots, F_m)^\top$ is*

$$DF := \left(\frac{\partial F_j}{\partial x_k} \right)_{1 \leq j \leq m}^{1 \leq k \leq d} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}.$$

iv) *The divergence of $F = (F_1, \dots, F_m)^\top$ is*

$$\operatorname{div} F := \sum_{j=1}^d \frac{\partial F_j}{\partial x_j} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}.$$

We collect continuous functions with continuous partial derivatives of the same degree in the following well-known function spaces.

Definition 2.13 (Spaces of Continuously Differentiable Functions). *We denote by $\mathcal{C}^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ the space of continuous functions $f : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$ and by*

$$\mathcal{C}^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \left\{ f \in \mathcal{C}^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \mid |\alpha| \leq k \Rightarrow D^\alpha f \in \mathcal{C}^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \right\}, \quad k \geq 0,$$

the space of such functions that are continuously differentiable up to order $k \geq 0$. Moreover,

$$\mathcal{C}^\infty(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \bigcap_{k \geq 0} \mathcal{C}^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$$

denotes the space of infinitely continuously differentiable functions.

A particular subspace of $\mathcal{C}^\infty(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is of particular interest to us and the concept of distributional derivatives. This is the space of *test functions*.

Definition 2.14 (Test Function). *The space $\mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ contains all infinitely often differentiable functions with compact support in Ω , i.e.*

$$\mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) = \{ f \in \mathcal{C}^\infty(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \mid \operatorname{supp}(f) \subset \Omega \text{ compact} \}$$

For $m = 1$, we abbreviate $\mathcal{D}(\Omega) := \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^1)$ and note that

$$\mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) = (\mathcal{D}(\Omega))^m, \quad \forall m \geq 1.$$

*A function $f \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is called a **test function**.*

Finally, we can define what a *distribution* is.

Definition 2.15 (Distribution). A distribution T is a linear continuous functional on the test function space $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$, i.e. $T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$. For $m \geq 1$ we set

$$\mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := (\mathcal{D}'(\Omega))^m$$

and for $T = (T_1, \dots, T_m) \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ and $\varphi = (\varphi_1, \dots, \varphi_m) \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ we use the duality pairing

$$\langle T, \varphi \rangle := \sum_{j=1}^m \langle T_j, \varphi_j \rangle.$$

Definition 2.16 (Partial derivatives of distributions). Let $T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$. For $\alpha \in \mathbb{N}_0^d$ we define the distributional partial derivative $D^\alpha T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ of T by

$$\langle D^\alpha T, \varphi \rangle := (-1)^{|\alpha|} \langle T, D^\alpha \varphi \rangle \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega).$$

If $T = (T_1, \dots, T_m) \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$, we set

$$D^\alpha T := (D^\alpha T_1, \dots, D^\alpha T_m) \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m).$$

Definition 2.17 (Distributional Gradient and Divergence). Let $x = (x_1, \dots, x_d)^\top \in \Omega$.

i) The distributional gradient of $T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ is defined by

$$\nabla T := \left(\frac{\partial T}{\partial x_1}, \dots, \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_d} \right) \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d),$$

where each partial derivative $\partial T / \partial x_j$, $1 \leq j \leq d$ is taken in the sense of Definition 2.16 and it holds that

$$\langle \nabla T, \varphi \rangle = -\langle T, \operatorname{div} \varphi \rangle \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$$

ii) The distributional divergence of $T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ is defined by

$$\operatorname{div} T := \sum_{j=1}^d \frac{\partial T_j}{\partial x_j} \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega), \quad T = (T_1, \dots, T_d).$$

where each partial derivative $\partial T_j / \partial x_j$, $1 \leq j \leq d$ is taken in the sense of Definition 2.16 and it holds that

$$\langle \operatorname{div} T, \varphi \rangle = -\langle T, \nabla \varphi \rangle \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega).$$

Definition 2.18 (Locally Integrable Functions). The space $L_{\text{loc}}^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ of all locally integrable functions on Ω is defined as

$$L_{\text{loc}}^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \left\{ f : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m \text{ measurable} \mid |f|_K \in L^1(K; \mathbb{R}^m) \forall K \subset \Omega, K \text{ compact} \right\}.$$

Definition 2.19 (Regular Distribution). A regular distribution $T_f \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is one of the form

$$\langle T_f, \varphi \rangle = \int_{\Omega} f \varphi \, dx, \quad f \in L_{\text{loc}}^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m).$$

In particular, the map

$$\mathcal{T} : L_{\text{loc}}^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \rightarrow \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m), \quad f \mapsto T_f$$

is injective and $\text{Im } \mathcal{T} \subset \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is the subspace of regular distributions.

2.8 Sobolev Spaces

Throughout, for $u, v : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$ we denote by $u \cdot v$ the Euclidean inner product in $\mathbb{R}^m$ and by $|u| := \sqrt{u \cdot u}$ the associated Euclidean norm.

Proposition 2.3 (*L^2 -Functions are Locally Integrable*). *The space $L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ of square-integrable functions on Ω is a subspace of $L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$. Consequently, every $f \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is infinitely differentiable in the sense of distributions.*

Proof. Let $K \subset \Omega$ be compact and $f \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$. Then $f \in L^2(K; \mathbb{R}^m)$, i.e. $\|f\|_{L^2(K; \mathbb{R}^m)} < \infty$ and by Cauchy-Schwarz we have

$$\|f\|_{L^1(K; \mathbb{R}^m)} = \int_K |f| \, dx \leq \left(\int_K |f|^2 \, dx \right)^{1/2} \left(\int_K 1^2 \, dx \right)^{1/2} = \|f\|_{L^2(K; \mathbb{R}^m)} |K|^{1/2} < \infty,$$

where $|\cdot|$ denotes the Lebesgue measure on $\mathbb{R}^d$. ■

Definition 2.20 (Sobolev Spaces of Integer Order). *Let $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ be open, $m \geq 1$, $k \in \mathbb{N}_0$ and $1 \leq p < \infty$. The Sobolev space $W^{k,p}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is defined by*

$$W^{k,p}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \left\{ u \in L^p(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \mid D^\alpha u \in L^p(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \, \forall \alpha \in \mathbb{N}_0^d, |\alpha| \leq k \right\},$$

where $D^\alpha u$ is understood in the sense of distributions. We adopt the usual conventions $H^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := W^{k,2}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ and $H^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ and we denote the corresponding dual space by $H^{-k}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$. Finally, we denote by

$$(u, v)_{0,\Omega} := (u, v)_{L^2(\Omega)} = \int_\Omega u \cdot v \, dx, \quad u, v \in H^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

the L^2 -product and analogously the L^2 -norm by

$$\|u\|_{0,\Omega} := \|u\|_{L^2(\Omega)} = \left(\int_\Omega |u|^2 \, dx \right)^{1/2}, \quad u \in H^0(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

Proposition 2.4 ($H^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is a Hilbert space). *The Sobolev space $H^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ together with the inner product*

$$(u, v)_{k,\Omega} := \sum_{|\alpha| \leq k} (D^\alpha u, D^\alpha v)_{0,\Omega}, \quad u, v \in H^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$$

is a Hilbert space and it induces the norm

$$\|u\|_{k,\Omega} = \left(\sum_{|\alpha| \leq k} \|D^\alpha u\|_{0,\Omega}^2 \right)^{1/2} < \infty, \quad u \in H^k(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m).$$

□

Definition 2.21 (Sobolev Spaces of Fractional Order). *For $1 \leq p < \infty$ and $\theta \in (0, 1)$ set*

$$|u|_{\theta,p,\Omega} := \left(\int_\Omega \int_\Omega \frac{|u(x) - u(y)|^p}{|x - y|^{d+p\theta}} \, dx \, dy \right)^{1/p}, \quad u \in W^{k,p}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m).$$

The Sobolev space of order $s = k + \theta \in \mathbb{R}_{>0} \setminus \mathbb{N}$, $k \in \mathbb{N}_0$ is defined by

$$W^{s,p}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := \left\{ u \in W^{k,p}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) \mid |D^\alpha u|_{\theta,p,\Omega} < \infty, |\alpha| = k \right\}.$$

We adopt the usual convention $H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m) := W^{s,2}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$. The corresponding dual space is denoted by $H^{-s}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$.

Proposition 2.5 ($H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ is a Banach space). The Sobolev space $H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$ defined in Definition 2.21 together with the norm

$$\|u\|_{s,\Omega} := \left(\|u\|_{k,\Omega}^2 + \sum_{|\alpha|=k} |D^\alpha u|_{\theta,2,\Omega}^2 \right)^{1/2}, \quad u \in H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$$

is a Banach space. □

Theorem 2.1 (Trace Theorem).

3 Signorini's Problem

3.1 Physical and Geometric Setup of the Problem

We consider an elastic body occupying a reference configuration $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$, $d \in \{2, 3\}$. Under the action of external forces and possible contact with a rigid foundation, the body deforms. In the *small-strain* framework, the deformation is described by the *displacement field* $u : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d$, and a material point $x \in \Omega$ is mapped to its deformed position

$$\varphi(x) := x' := x + u(x), \quad x \in \overline{\Omega}.$$

The aim of Signorini's problem is to determine an *equilibrium* displacement u under standard boundary conditions and *unilateral* contact constraints on the part of the boundary that may touch the rigid foundation. Throughout the whole report, $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$, $d \in \{2, 3\}$ denotes an open, bounded and connected *Lipschitz* domain. The latter means, that the boundary $\Gamma := \partial\Omega$ can locally be described as the graph of a Lipschitz continuous function. This ensures for example, that the outward normal vector $\mathbf{n}(x)$ is well-defined almost everywhere. The boundary is decomposed into three pairwise disjoint parts

$$\Gamma = \overline{\Gamma_D} \dot{\cup} \overline{\Gamma_N} \dot{\cup} \overline{\Gamma_C}$$

which are assumed to be open in Γ and where each part is subject to different boundary conditions to model different physical interactions (See Figure 1). On Γ_D , we apply *homogeneous Dirichlet* boundary conditions. This forces the body to be *clamped* and this part, i.e. the displacement should not act on Γ_D ,

$$\forall x \in \Gamma_D : x + u(x) = x \quad \implies \quad \text{Tr}(u)|_{\Gamma_D} = 0.$$

The part Γ_N may be subject to a *Neumann* boundary condition, which means we impose a known *surface force density*. Γ_C denotes the *potential contact* boundary. We assume that Γ_C and Γ_D have positive $(d - 1)$ -Lebesgue measure. The rigid foundation is positioned so that any actual contact, both initially and in the deformed equilibrium configuration, may only occur on Γ_C . While Γ_C is prescribed a priori, the *active contact zone* $\Gamma_{\text{act}}(u) \subset \Gamma_C$ is unknown and depends on the solution u . Later on, the boundary conditions imposed on Γ_C enforce *unilateral* contact through *nonpenetration* and *complementarity*.

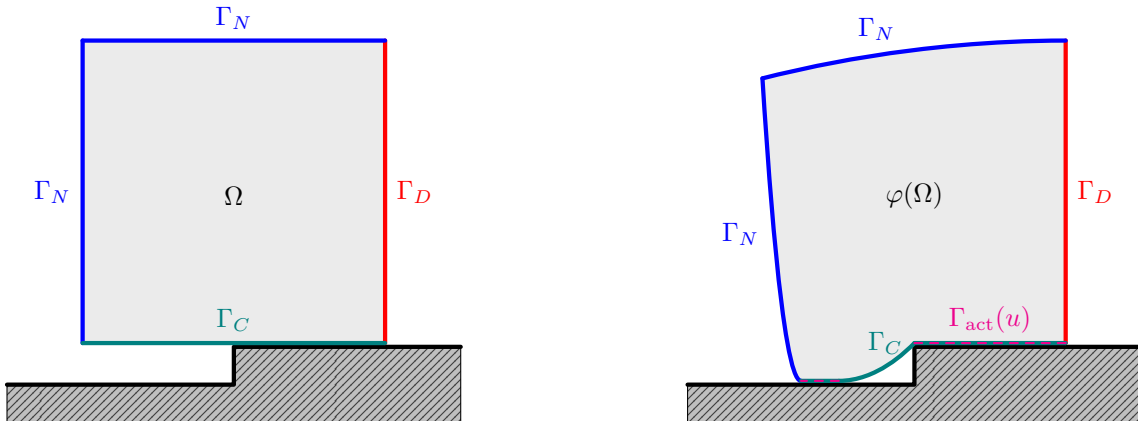


Figure 1: 2D example of Signorini's problem before (left) and after displacement (right).

3.2 Weak Formulation

3.2.1 Admissible Displacements

We start by introducing the energy space and the admissible set of displacements. Homogeneous Dirichlet boundary conditions on Γ_D are incorporated by

$$V := \left\{ v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d) \mid \text{Tr}(v) = 0 \text{ on } \Gamma_D \right\} \subset H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d). \quad (3.1)$$

Let $\gamma = \text{Tr} : H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d) \rightarrow H^{1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$ denote the trace operator. For $v \in V$ we define the normal component of the boundary displacement on Γ_C by

$$v_n := (\gamma v) \cdot \mathbf{n} \quad \text{on } \Gamma_C,$$

where $\mathbf{n}$ is the outward unit normal on Γ . The unilateral nature of contact is expressed by the *nonpenetration* constraint. The rigid foundation is located on the exterior side of Γ_C in direction of $\mathbf{n}$. Hence the body is not allowed to move across Γ_C into the obstacle. In the small-strain setting this yields

$$u_n \leq 0 \quad \text{a.e. on } \Gamma_C.$$

This motivates the nonempty, closed and convex cone ([1, Prop. 3.1]) of admissible displacements

$$K := \{ v \in V \mid v_n \leq 0 \text{ a.e. on } \Gamma_C \} \subset V. \quad (3.2)$$

3.2.2 Small Strain Elasticity

We start by defining the *small strain tensor* for a displacement function $u \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, which is similar to the symmetric part of square matrices but for the gradient ∇u of u and through which the deformation of the body $\bar{\Omega}$ by u is quantified.

Definition 3.1 (Small Strain Tensor). *The small strain tensor ε is defined by*

$$\varepsilon(u) := \frac{1}{2} \left(\nabla u + \nabla u^\top \right) \in L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)), \quad u \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

We denote by $\text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$ the space of symmetric second order tensors,

$$\text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d) := \left\{ s \in \mathbb{R}^d \otimes \mathbb{R}^d \mid s^\top = s \right\} \cong \left\{ S \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d} \mid S^\top = S \right\}.$$

For $s, t \in \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$ we write denote by

$$s : t := \sum_{i=1}^d \sum_{j=1}^d s_{ij} t_{ij}$$

If $A(x)$ is a fourth order tensor and $s \in \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$, we use the *double contraction*

$$(A(x) : s)_{ij} := \sum_{k=1}^d \sum_{l=1}^d A_{ijkl}(x) s_{kl}, \quad s : A(x) : s := \sum_{i=1}^d \sum_{j=1}^d \sum_{k=1}^d \sum_{l=1}^d A_{ijkl}(x) s_{ij} s_{kl}.$$

In linear elasticity, stresses are assumed to depend linearly on strains. The material response is encoded in the fourth order *elasticity tensor* A , which maps a symmetric strain tensor to the corresponding *Cauchy stress tensor*. The tensor field A is prescribed by the material and may vary in space, describing a *heterogeneous* body.

Definition 3.2 (Elasticity tensor field). *An elasticity tensor field is a mapping*

$$A : \Omega \rightarrow \mathcal{L}(\text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d); \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$$

such that the coefficients satisfy the symmetries

$$A_{ijkl}(x) = A_{jikl}(x) = A_{ijlk}(x) = A_{klij}(x), \quad \forall 1 \leq i, j, k, l \leq d,$$

and the uniform ellipticity condition, i.e. there exists $\alpha_A > 0$ such that for a.e. $x \in \Omega$

$$s : A(x) : s \geq \alpha_A (s : s) \quad \forall s \in \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d).$$

Moreover, there exists $C_A > 0$ such that for a.e. $x \in \Omega$

$$|A_{ijkl}(x)| \leq C_A \quad \forall 1 \leq i, j, k, l \leq d.$$

The *internal* and *surface forces* in the body $\bar{\Omega}$ are described by the *Cauchy stress tensor*.

Definition 3.3 (Cauchy stress tensor). *Let A be an elasticity tensor field. For $u \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ we define the (linear) Cauchy stress tensor as the field $\sigma(u) \in L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ given a.e. by*

$$\sigma(u)(x) := A(x) : \varepsilon(u)(x).$$

On V , we define the symmetric bilinear form

$$a(u, v) := \int_{\Omega} \sigma(u) : \varepsilon(v) \, dx, \quad u, v \in V \quad (3.3)$$

representing the *virtual work of internal forces* and the linear bounded functional

$$\ell(v) := \int_{\Omega} f \cdot v \, dx + \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma v \, ds, \quad v \in V, \quad (3.4)$$

with *volume force density* $f \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ on the body and *surface loads* $F \in L^2(\Gamma_N; \mathbb{R}^d)$ on the Neumann boundary, representing the *virtual work of external forces*. In the following, we want to prove standard properties of a and ℓ . For this, we will need the following inequalities. The first inequality is a result of *Korn's second inequality* ([1, Theorem 3.3] and [1, Section 3.5.2]) and the *Peetre–Tartar Lemma* ([1, Lemma 3.5]). Therefore only the proof of the second one is given.

Lemma 3.1. *Assuming $|\Gamma_D| > 0$, there exists a constant $C_K > 0$ such that*

$$C_K^{-1} \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \leq \|\varepsilon(v)\|_{0,\Omega} \leq \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \quad \forall v \in V.$$

Proof. We prove the second inequality. For all $v \in V$ we have

$$|\varepsilon(v)(x)| = \left| \frac{1}{2}(\nabla v(x) + \nabla v(x)^\top) \right| \leq \frac{1}{2}(|\nabla v(x)| + |\nabla v(x)^\top|) = |\nabla v(x)|$$

and thus

$$\|\varepsilon(v)\|_{0,\Omega}^2 = \int_{\Omega} |\varepsilon(v)(x)|^2 \, dx \leq \int_{\Omega} |\nabla v(x)|^2 \, dx = \|\nabla v\|_{0,\Omega}^2 \leq \|v\|_{1,\Omega}^2,$$

where the last inequality holds due to the definition

$$\|v\|_{1,\Omega}^2 = \|v\|_{0,\Omega}^2 + \|\nabla v\|_{0,\Omega}^2.$$

■

Proposition 3.1. *The symmetric bilinear form $a : V \times V \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ defined in (3.3) is*

i) *bounded, i.e. for all $v, w \in V$ there exists $C_1 < \infty$ such that*

$$|a(u, v)| \leq C_1 \|u\|_{1,\Omega} \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \quad \text{with} \quad C_1 = C_A,$$

ii) *V-elliptic, i.e. for all $v \in V \setminus \{0\}$ there exist $C_2 > 0$ such that*

$$a(v, v) \geq C_2 \|v\|_{1,\Omega}^2 \quad \text{with} \quad C_2 = \frac{\alpha_A}{C_K^2}.$$

Moreover, the linear functional ℓ defined in (3.4) is bounded, i.e. for all $v \in V$ there exists $C_3 > 0$ such that

$$|\ell(v)| \leq C_3 \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \quad \text{with} \quad C_3 = \max\{1, C_{\text{tr}}\} (\|f\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F\|_{0,\Gamma_N}) \|v\|_{1,\Omega}. \quad (3.5)$$

Proof. Let $v, w \in V$ be arbitrary. Then

$$|a(v, w)| \leq \|A : \varepsilon(v)\|_{0,\Omega} \|\varepsilon(w)\|_{0,\Omega}$$

by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality. With Definition 3.2 there exists $C_A > 0$ such that

$$\|A : \varepsilon(v)\|_{0,\Omega} \leq C_A \|\varepsilon(v)\|_{0,\Omega}.$$

Combining this with the second inequality from Lemma 3.1 we have

$$|a(v, w)| \leq C_A \|\varepsilon(v)\|_{0,\Omega} \|\varepsilon(w)\|_{0,\Omega} \leq C_A \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \|w\|_{1,\Omega}.$$

The ellipticity of a follows by

$$a(v, v) = \int_{\Omega} \varepsilon(v) : A : \varepsilon(v) \, dx \geq \alpha_A \int_{\Omega} \varepsilon(v) : \varepsilon(v) = \alpha_A \|\varepsilon(v)\|_{0,\Omega}^2,$$

where $\alpha_A > 0$ exists due to Definition 3.2. The first inequality of Lemma 3.1 finally yields

$$a(v, v) \geq \alpha_A \|\varepsilon(v)\|_{0,\Omega}^2 \geq \alpha_A \left(C_K^{-1} \|v\|_{1,\Omega}\right)^2 = \frac{\alpha_A}{C_K^2} \|v\|_{1,\Omega}^2.$$

Again by Cauchy–Schwarz inequality,

$$|\ell(v)| \leq \|f\|_{0,\Omega} \|v\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F\|_{0,\Gamma_N} \|\gamma v\|_{0,\Gamma_N} \quad \forall v \in V.$$

By the Trace Theorem 2.1 there exists $C_{\text{tr}} > 0$ such that

$$\|\gamma v\|_{0,\Gamma_N} \leq \|\gamma v\|_{0,\Gamma} \leq \|\gamma v\|_{\frac{1}{2},\Gamma} \leq C_{\text{tr}} \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \quad \forall v \in V.$$

Finally,

$$|\ell(v)| \leq (\|f\|_{0,\Omega} + C_{\text{tr}} \|F\|_{0,\Gamma_N}) \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \leq \max\{1, C_{\text{tr}}\} (\|f\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F\|_{0,\Gamma_N}) \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \quad \forall v \in V. \quad \blacksquare$$

3.2.3 Energy Minimization and Well-posedness

The total potential energy of the elastic body is given by the quadratic functional

$$\mathcal{J}(v) := \frac{1}{2} a(v, v) - \ell(v), \quad v \in V. \quad (3.6)$$

In the presence of unilateral contact, the admissible displacements are restricted to the closed convex set $K \subset V$. We therefore consider the following constrained minimization problem.

Problem 3.1 (Signorini's Problem – Energy Minimization). *Find $u \in K$ such that*

$$\mathcal{J}(u) = \min_{v \in K} \mathcal{J}(v) = \min_{v \in K} \frac{1}{2} a(v, v) - \ell(v).$$

We now what to prove well-posedness of the above Problem 3.1. This consist of existence and uniqueness of a solution and continuous dependency of the solution on the load functional ℓ . We start by the uniqueness, which follows directly by the strict convexity of $\mathcal{J}$ and the convexity of K .

Lemma 3.2 (Strict Convexity of $\mathcal{J}$). *The Functional $\mathcal{J}$ defined in (3.6) is strictly convex.*

Proof. For $u, v \in V$ and $t \in [0, 1]$, we set $w_t := (1 - t)u + tv$. Then

$$a(w_t, w_t) = (1 - t)a(u, u) + ta(v, v) - t(1 - t)a(u - v, u - v)$$

and

$$\ell(w_t) = (1 - t)\ell(u) + t\ell(v).$$

Together, we have

$$\mathcal{J}(w_t) = (1 - t)\mathcal{J}(u) + t\mathcal{J}(v) - \frac{1}{2}t(1 - t)a(u - v, u - v).$$

If $u \neq v$ then $u - v \neq 0$ and thus by V -ellipticity of a we have $a(u - v, u - v) > 0$ and $t(1 - t) > 0$. This implies

$$\mathcal{J}(w_t) < (1 - t)\mathcal{J}(u) + t\mathcal{J}(v).$$

■

Proposition 3.2 (Uniqueness of Minimizer of $\mathcal{J}$). *If there exists a minimizer of the functional $\mathcal{J}$ defined in (3.6), then it is unique.*

Proof. Assume that there exist two minimizers $u_1, u_2 \in K$ of $\mathcal{J}$ on K , i.e.

$$\mathcal{J}(u_1) = \min_{v \in K} \mathcal{J}(v) = \mathcal{J}(u_2). \quad (3.7)$$

If $u_1 = u_2$ there is nothing to show. Hence assume $u_1 \neq u_2$. Since K is convex, for every $t \in (0, 1)$ the convex combination

$$w_t := (1 - t)u_1 + tu_2$$

belongs to K . By Lemma 3.2, $\mathcal{J}$ is strictly convex and therefore we have

$$\mathcal{J}(w_t) < (1 - t)\mathcal{J}(u_1) + t\mathcal{J}(u_2) \quad \forall t \in (0, 1).$$

Using (3.7), this yields

$$\mathcal{J}(w_t) < (1 - t) \min_{v \in K} \mathcal{J}(v) + t \min_{v \in K} \mathcal{J}(v) = \min_{v \in K} \mathcal{J}(v).$$

This contradicts the definition of the minimum, since $w_t \in K$. Therefore the assumption $u_1 \neq u_2$ is false and we conclude $u_1 = u_2$. ■

It remains to show the existence of at least one minimizer. For this, we verify *coercivity* and *weakly lower semicontinuity* of the functional $\mathcal{J}$. The proof requires the following lemma.

Lemma 3.3 (Weak lower semicontinuity of the norm). *Let $(X, \|\cdot\|_X)$ be a normed space. Then $\|\cdot\|_X : X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ is a weakly lower semicontinuous functional, i.e. if $x_j \rightharpoonup x$ in X , then*

$$\|x\|_X \leq \liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} \|x_j\|_X.$$

Proof. Let $J : X \rightarrow X^{**}$ be the canonical embedding defined by

$$(Jx)(\varphi) := \varphi(x) \quad \forall \varphi \in X^*.$$

By the Hahn–Banach theorem, J is an isometry, i.e. $\|Jx\|_{X^{**}} = \|x\|_X$ for all $x \in X$. Therefore,

$$\|x\|_X = \|Jx\|_{X^{**}} = \sup_{\substack{\varphi \in X^* \\ \|\varphi\|_{X^*} \leq 1}} |(Jx)(\varphi)| = \sup_{\substack{\varphi \in X^* \\ \|\varphi\|_{X^*} \leq 1}} |\varphi(x)|.$$

If $x_j \rightharpoonup x$ in X , then $\varphi(x_j) \rightarrow \varphi(x)$ for all $\varphi \in X^*$ and hence

$$\|x\|_X = \sup_{\substack{\varphi \in X^* \\ \|\varphi\|_{X^*} \leq 1}} |\varphi(x)| \leq \liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} \sup_{\substack{\varphi \in X^* \\ \|\varphi\|_{X^*} \leq 1}} |\varphi(x_j)| = \liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} \|x_j\|_X.$$

■

Lemma 3.4 ($\mathcal{J}$ is coercive and w.l.s.c.). *The functional $\mathcal{J}$ defined in (3.6) is*

i) *coercive on V , i.e.*

$$\mathcal{J}(v) \rightarrow \infty \quad \text{as} \quad \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \rightarrow \infty,$$

ii) *weakly lower semicontinuous on V , i.e. if $v_j \rightharpoonup v$ in V , then*

$$\mathcal{J}(v) \leq \liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} \mathcal{J}(v_j).$$

Proof. By boundedness of ℓ we have $|\ell(v)| \leq \|\ell\|_{-1,\Omega} \|v\|_{1,\Omega}$. Hence

$$\mathcal{J}(v) = \frac{1}{2} a(v, v) - \ell(v) \geq \frac{\alpha}{2} \|v\|_{1,\Omega}^2 - \|\ell\|_{-1,\Omega} \|v\|_{1,\Omega} \xrightarrow{\|v\|_{1,\Omega} \rightarrow \infty} \infty.$$

For $s \in L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ set

$$\|s\|_A^2 := \int_{\Omega} s : A : s \, dx.$$

By uniform ellipticity of A , the map $\|\cdot\|_A$ defines a norm on $L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ equivalent to $\|\cdot\|_{0,\Omega}$. Moreover, $a(v, v) = \|\varepsilon(v)\|_A^2$. The mapping $v \mapsto \varepsilon(v)$ is linear and bounded from V to $L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$. Hence, if $v_j \rightharpoonup v$ in V , then

$$\varepsilon(v_j) \rightharpoonup \varepsilon(v) \quad \text{in } L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d)).$$

Since norms are weakly lower semicontinuous by Lemma 3.3, we obtain

$$a(v, v) = \|\varepsilon(v)\|_A^2 \leq \liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} \|\varepsilon(v_j)\|_A^2 = \liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} a(v_j, v_j).$$

Furthermore, $\ell \in V'$ is weakly continuous, hence $\ell(v_j) \rightarrow \ell(v)$. Therefore,

$$\mathcal{J}(v) = \frac{1}{2} a(v, v) - \ell(v) \leq \frac{1}{2} \liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} a(v_j, v_j) - \lim_{j \rightarrow \infty} \ell(v_j) = \liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} \mathcal{J}(v_j).$$

■

Proposition 3.3 (Existence of Minimizer of $\mathcal{J}$). *The functional $\mathcal{J}$ defined in 3.6 has at least one minimizer $u \in K$.*

Proof. Set

$$M := \inf_{v \in K} \mathcal{J}(v) \in [-\infty, \infty).$$

Since $0 \in K$ we have $M \leq \mathcal{J}(0) = 0$, hence M is finite from above. Let $\{v_j\}_{j \in \mathbb{N}} \subset K$ be a minimizing sequence, i.e. $\mathcal{J}(v_j) \rightarrow M$ as $j \rightarrow \infty$. By Lemma 3.4 i), $\mathcal{J}$ is coercive and thus, the sequence $\{v_j\}_{j \in \mathbb{N}}$ is bounded in V . Since V is a Hilbert space, there exist a subsequence $\{v_{j_k}\}_{k \in \mathbb{N}}$ and some $u \in V$ such that

$$v_{j_k} \rightharpoonup u \quad \text{in } V.$$

As $K \subset V$ is closed and convex, it is weakly closed in V . Hence $u \in K$. By Lemma 3.4 ii), $\mathcal{J}$ is weakly lower semicontinuity and thus we obtain

$$\mathcal{J}(u) \leq \liminf_{k \rightarrow \infty} \mathcal{J}(v_{j_k}) = M = \inf_{v \in K} \mathcal{J}(v),$$

so u is a minimizer of $\mathcal{J}$ on K . ■

Corollary 3.1 (Well-posedness of Problem 3.1). *The functional $\mathcal{J}$ defined in 3.6 admits a unique minimizer $u \in K$. Moreover, the minimizer satisfies the a-priori bound*

$$\|u\|_{1,\Omega} \leq \frac{2C_K^2 \max\{1, C_{\text{tr}}\}}{\alpha_A} (\|f\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F\|_{0,\Gamma_N}). \quad (3.8)$$

Consequently, Problem 3.1 has a unique stable solution.

Proof. By Proposition 3.3 we have existence of a solution $u \in K$ to Problem 3.1 and by Proposition 3.2 it is unique. It remains to prove the a-priori bound. Since u is the unique minimizer, it holds

$$\mathcal{J}(u) \leq \mathcal{J}(0) = 0 \quad \implies \quad \frac{1}{2} a(u, u) \leq \ell(u).$$

By Proposition 3.1 ii) we have

$$a(u, u) \geq \frac{\alpha_A}{C_K^2} \|u\|_{1,\Omega}^2$$

and thus

$$\frac{\alpha_A}{2C_K^2} \|u\|_{1,\Omega}^2 \leq \frac{1}{2} a(u, u) \leq |\ell(u)| \leq \max\{1, C_{\text{tr}}\} (\|f\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F\|_{0,\Gamma_N}) \|u\|_{1,\Omega},$$

where the last inequality is (3.5). Dividing both sides by $\|u\|_{1,\Omega}$ yields the desired estimate (3.8). For $u = 0$ the estimate is trivial. ■

3.2.4 Variational inequality as an optimality condition

Finally, we turn to the *weak formulation* of Signorini's problem. Unlike the weak formulation of conventional simple boundary value problems, here we do not end up with a variational equation, but with a variational inequality. This is derived by a first-order optimality condition on the functional $\mathcal{J}$.

Lemma 3.5 (Fréchet differentiability of $\mathcal{J}$). *The functional $\mathcal{J}$ defined in (3.6) is Fréchet differentiable on V . Its derivative at $u \in V$ is given by*

$$\mathcal{J}'(u)[h] = a(u, h) - \ell(h) \quad \forall h \in V. \quad (3.9)$$

Proof. Let $u, h \in V$ and $t \in \mathbb{R}$. Using bilinearity of a and linearity of ℓ we compute

$$\mathcal{J}(u + th) - \mathcal{J}(u) = \frac{1}{2} (a(u + th, u + th) - a(u, u)) - t\ell(h) = t(a(u, h) - \ell(h)) + \frac{t^2}{2} a(h, h).$$

Hence

$$\frac{\mathcal{J}(u + th) - \mathcal{J}(u) - t(a(u, h) - \ell(h))}{\|th\|_{1,\Omega}} = \frac{|t|}{2} \frac{|a(h, h)|}{\|h\|_{1,\Omega}} \leq \frac{|t|}{2} C_A \|h\|_{1,\Omega} \xrightarrow{t \rightarrow 0} 0,$$

by boundedness of a as proven in Proposition 3.1. ■

Proposition 3.4 (First-order optimality condition on convex sets). *A function $u \in K$ minimizes $\mathcal{J}$ over K if and only if it satisfies the variational inequality*

$$\mathcal{J}'(u)[v - u] \geq 0 \quad \forall v \in K. \quad (3.10)$$

Proof. Assume first that $u \in K$ minimizes $\mathcal{J}$ over K and let $v \in K$. By convexity of K we have $u + t(v - u) \in K$ for all $t \in [0, 1]$. Define $\phi(t) := \mathcal{J}(u + t(v - u))$. Then ϕ attains its minimum at $t = 0$, hence $\phi'(0^+) \geq 0$. Using the chain rule and Fréchet differentiability of $\mathcal{J}$ we obtain

$$\phi'(0^+) = \mathcal{J}'(u)[v - u] \geq 0.$$

Conversely, assume (3.10). Let $v \in K$ be arbitrary and set $h := v - u$. By Taylor expansion of the quadratic functional $\mathcal{J}$ we have

$$\mathcal{J}(u + h) - \mathcal{J}(u) = \mathcal{J}'(u)[h] + \frac{1}{2} a(h, h).$$

By (3.10), $\mathcal{J}'(u)[h] \geq 0$, and since $a(h, h) \geq 0$ we conclude $\mathcal{J}(v) \geq \mathcal{J}(u)$ for all $v \in K$. Hence u is a minimizer over K . ■

Combining Lemma 3.5 and Proposition 3.4, $u \in K$ solves Problem 3.1 if and only if

$$\mathcal{J}'(u)[v - u] = a(u, v - u) - \ell(v - u) \geq 0 \quad \forall v \in K.$$

This is the first weak formulation of Signorini's problem as a variational inequality.

Problem 3.2 (Signorini's Problem – Weak Formulation). *Find $u \in K$ such that*

$$a(u, v - u) \geq \ell(v - u) \quad \forall v \in K.$$

Well-posedness of Problem 3.2 is already ensured, since it is equivalent to the minimization Problem 3.1 in the sense that each solution to the one of the problems is a solution to the other problem (Proposition 3.4). The solution is unique due to Corollary 3.1 with the stability estimate (3.8). Another useful equivalent formulation is the following.

Problem 3.3 (Signorini's Problem – Weak Formulation). *Find $u \in K$ such that*

$$\begin{cases} a(u, u) = \ell(u), \\ a(u, v) \geq \ell(v) \quad \forall v \in K. \end{cases}$$

Proposition 3.5 (Equivalence of Problem 3.2 and Problem 3.3). *Any solution $u \in K$ to Problem 3.2 is also a solution to Problem 3.3 and vice versa.*

Proof. Let $u \in K$ solve Problem 3.3. Then

$$a(u, v - u) = a(u, v) - a(u, u) = a(u, v) - \ell(u) \geq \ell(v) - \ell(u) = \ell(v - u).$$

Assuming that $u \in K$ solves Problem 3.2 and testing $v = 0$

$$a(u, -u) \geq \ell(-u) \iff -a(u, u) \geq -\ell(u) \iff a(u, u) \leq \ell(u).$$

However, testing with $v = 2u$ yields $a(u, u) \geq \ell(u)$ and thus $a(u, u) = \ell(u)$. Furthermore, Problem 3.2 reads

$$a(u, v - u) = a(u, v) - a(u, u) \geq \ell(v - u) = \ell(v) - \ell(u) \implies a(u, v) \geq a(u, u) + \ell(v) - \ell(u).$$

Plugging in $a(u, u) = \ell(u)$ yields $a(u, v) \geq \ell(v)$. ■

We close this section by providing another stability result on the dependency of solutions to varying source terms as input data.

Proposition 3.6 (Lipschitz dependency). *Let $f_1, f_2 \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ and $F_1, F_2 \in L^2(\Gamma_N; \mathbb{R}^d)$ and let $\ell_i \in V'$ be the corresponding load functionals*

$$\ell_i(v) = \int_{\Omega} f_i \cdot v \, dx + \int_{\Gamma_N} F_i \cdot \gamma v \, ds, \quad v \in V, \quad i = 1, 2.$$

Let $u_i \in K$ be the corresponding (unique) minimizers of

$$\mathcal{J}_i(v) := \frac{1}{2} a(v, v) - \ell_i(v)$$

over K . Then the solutions depend Lipschitz continuously on the data, i.e.

$$\|u_1 - u_2\|_{1,\Omega} \leq \frac{C_K^2}{\alpha_A} \|\ell_1 - \ell_2\|_{-1,\Omega} \leq \frac{C_K^2 \max\{1, C_{\text{tr}}\}}{\alpha_A} (\|f_1 - f_2\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F_1 - F_2\|_{0,\Gamma_N}).$$

Proof. Since $u_i \in K$ minimizes $\mathcal{J}_i$ over the closed convex set K by Proposition 3.4, it satisfies the first-order optimality condition

$$a(u_i, v - u_i) \geq \ell_i(v - u_i) \quad \forall v \in K, \quad i = 1, 2. \tag{3.11}$$

Choose $v = u_2$ in (3.11) for $i = 1$ and $v = u_1$ in (3.11) for $i = 2$. This yields

$$\begin{aligned} a(u_1, u_2 - u_1) &\geq \ell_1(u_2 - u_1), \\ a(u_2, u_1 - u_2) &\geq \ell_2(u_1 - u_2). \end{aligned}$$

Adding both inequalities and using bilinearity of a gives

$$a(u_1 - u_2, u_1 - u_2) \leq (\ell_1 - \ell_2)(u_1 - u_2).$$

By the V -ellipticity estimate from Proposition 3.1 ii) we have

$$a(w, w) \geq \frac{\alpha_A}{C_K^2} \|w\|_{1,\Omega}^2 \quad \forall w \in V.$$

Applying this with $w = u_1 - u_2$ and estimating the right-hand side by the dual norm $\|\cdot\|_{-1,\Omega}$ yields

$$\frac{\alpha_A}{C_K^2} \|u_1 - u_2\|_{1,\Omega}^2 \leq a(u_1 - u_2, u_1 - u_2) \leq \|\ell_1 - \ell_2\|_{-1,\Omega} \|u_1 - u_2\|_{1,\Omega}.$$

If $u_1 = u_2$ there is nothing to show. Otherwise we divide by $\|u_1 - u_2\|_{1,\Omega}$ and obtain

$$\|u_1 - u_2\|_{1,\Omega} \leq \frac{C_K^2}{\alpha_A} \|\ell_1 - \ell_2\|_{-1,\Omega}. \quad (3.12)$$

It remains to bound $\|\ell_1 - \ell_2\|_{-1,\Omega}$ in terms of $f_1 - f_2$ and $F_1 - F_2$. Let $v \in V$ be arbitrary. By Cauchy–Schwarz,

$$|(\ell_1 - \ell_2)(v)| \leq \|f_1 - f_2\|_{0,\Omega} \|v\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F_1 - F_2\|_{0,\Gamma_N} \|\gamma v\|_{0,\Gamma_N}.$$

Using $\|v\|_{0,\Omega} \leq \|v\|_{1,\Omega}$ and the trace estimate $\|\gamma v\|_{0,\Gamma_N} \leq C_{\text{tr}} \|v\|_{1,\Omega}$ we obtain

$$|(\ell_1 - \ell_2)(v)| \leq \max\{1, C_{\text{tr}}\} (\|f_1 - f_2\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F_1 - F_2\|_{0,\Gamma_N}) \|v\|_{1,\Omega}.$$

Dividing by $\|v\|_{1,\Omega}$ and taking the supremum over $0 \neq v \in V$ yields

$$\|\ell_1 - \ell_2\|_{-1,\Omega} \leq \max\{1, C_{\text{tr}}\} (\|f_1 - f_2\|_{0,\Omega} + \|F_1 - F_2\|_{0,\Gamma_N})$$

Combining this with (3.12) gives the claim. ■

3.3 Strong Formulation

From the previous weak formulations of Signorini’s problem, we know there exists a uniquely determined $u \in K$ that solves the problem. To derive a *strong* PDE formulation, we have to discuss what $\sigma(u)$ means and in what sense the contact conditions on Γ_C can be described as equalities and inequalities.

3.3.1 Stress Regularity and Boundary Traction

In the weak setting, the solution only satisfies $u \in K \subset H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, i.e. $\varepsilon(u) \in L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$ and, by $\sigma(u) = A : \varepsilon(u)$, we obtain $\sigma(u) \in L^2(\Omega; \text{Sym}^2(\mathbb{R}^d))$. This regularity is sufficient to interpret the internal virtual work

$$a(u, v) = \int_{\Omega} \sigma(u) : \varepsilon(v) \, dx,$$

but it is not enough to write the equilibrium equation $-\text{div } \sigma(u) = f$ as an identity in $L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, since the divergence of an L^2 -field is only defined in the sense of distributions. To formulate a strong equilibrium equation in $L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ and to give a meaning to *boundary tractions*, we assume additional regularity of the stress,

$$\sigma(u) \in H(\text{div}; \Omega) := \left\{ \tau \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}) \mid \text{div } \tau \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d) \right\}. \quad (3.13)$$

Here $\text{div } \tau$ is taken row-wise, i.e.

$$(\text{div } \tau)_i = \sum_{j=1}^d \partial_j \tau_{ij}$$

in the distributional sense. If $\sigma(u) \in H(\text{div}; \Omega)$, then $\text{div } \sigma(u) \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, so the equilibrium equation is well-defined. The same regularity is also exactly what is needed to define the boundary traction (or surface force density) associated with τ . Formally, for smooth τ one would write

$$\tau \mathbf{n} \quad \text{on } \Gamma,$$

where $\mathbf{n} : \Gamma \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d$ is the outward unit normal and $\tau \mathbf{n}$ denotes the pointwise matrix–vector product. However, for $\tau \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^{d \times d})$ a pointwise boundary trace is not available, so $\tau \mathbf{n}$ cannot

be defined as an $L^2(\Gamma)$ -function in general. One therefore starts from the classical integration by parts formula. If τ and v are smooth, then

$$\int_{\Omega} \tau : \nabla v \, dx + \int_{\Omega} (\operatorname{div} \tau) \cdot v \, dx = \int_{\Gamma} (\tau \mathbf{n}) \cdot v \, ds. \quad (3.14)$$

The key point now is that the left-hand side still makes sense for $\tau \in H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$ and $v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$. Hence, for fixed $\tau \in H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$ the map

$$F_{\tau}(v) := \int_{\Omega} \tau : \nabla v \, dx + \int_{\Omega} (\operatorname{div} \tau) \cdot v \, dx, \quad v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d),$$

defines a continuous linear functional on $H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$. The crucial observation is that F_{τ} depends only on the boundary trace γv . Indeed, if $w \in H_0^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, then $\gamma w = 0$, and we claim that $F_{\tau}(w) = 0$. To see this, we take a sequence $(w_m)_{m \in \mathbb{N}} \subset C_c^{\infty}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ with $w_m \rightarrow w$ in $H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$. Since $\operatorname{div} \tau \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, we have for all $w_m \in C_c^{\infty}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, that

$$\int_{\Omega} (\operatorname{div} \tau) \cdot w_m \, dx = - \int_{\Omega} \tau : \nabla w_m \, dx,$$

and therefore $F_{\tau}(w_m) = 0$ for all $m \in \mathbb{N}$. Passing to the limit $m \rightarrow \infty$ using the continuity of F_{τ} on $H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ yields $F_{\tau}(w) = 0$. Consequently, if $v_1, v_2 \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ satisfy $\gamma v_1 = \gamma v_2$, then $v_1 - v_2 \in H_0^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ and thus $F_{\tau}(v_1) = F_{\tau}(v_2)$. This is exactly the statement that F_{τ} depends only on γv . Since $\gamma : H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d) \rightarrow H^{1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$ is continuous and $\ker(\gamma) = H_0^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, the previous argument implies that F_{τ} induces a well-defined continuous linear functional on the trace space $H^{1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$. Hence there exists a unique element $\gamma_n(\tau) \in H^{-1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$ such that

$$\langle \gamma_n(\tau), \gamma v \rangle_{\Gamma} = \int_{\Omega} \tau : \nabla v \, dx + \int_{\Omega} (\operatorname{div} \tau) \cdot v \, dx \quad \forall v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d), \quad (3.15)$$

where $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle_{\Gamma}$ denotes the duality pairing of $H^{-1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d) \times H^{1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$. The operator $\gamma_n : H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega) \rightarrow H^{-1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$ is called the *normal trace operator* (see [1, Lemma 3.1]). In the smooth case, (3.15) reduces to (3.14), so $\gamma_n(\tau)$ coincides with the classical boundary function $\tau \mathbf{n}$. For this reason we write suggestively

$$\gamma_n(\tau) = \tau \mathbf{n} \in H^{-1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

Physically, $\tau \mathbf{n}$ is the traction vector (or surface force density) exerted across the boundary with outward normal $\mathbf{n}$, and in particular $t(u) := \sigma(u) \mathbf{n}$ is the surface force induced by the stress field $\sigma(u)$. Finally, since τ is symmetric, $\tau : \nabla v = \tau : \varepsilon(v)$ for all v , so (3.15) can be written in the symmetric form

$$\langle \tau \mathbf{n}, \gamma v \rangle_{\Gamma} = \int_{\Omega} \tau : \varepsilon(v) \, dx + \int_{\Omega} (\operatorname{div} \tau) \cdot v \, dx \quad \forall (v, \tau) \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d) \times H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega).$$

Applying this to $\tau = \sigma(u)$ and assuming $\sigma(u) \in H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$ provides

$$\langle \sigma(u) \mathbf{n}, \gamma v \rangle_{\Gamma} = \int_{\Omega} \sigma(u) : \varepsilon(v) \, dx + \int_{\Omega} (\operatorname{div} \sigma(u)) \cdot v \, dx \quad \forall v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d). \quad (3.16)$$

which will be needed in the strong Signorini conditions.

3.3.2 A Hybrid Formulation

Problem 3.4 (Signorini's Problem – Hybrid Formulation). *Find $u \in K$ such that*

$$\begin{cases} -\operatorname{div} \sigma(u) = f & \text{a.e. in } \Omega, \\ \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma u \rangle_\Gamma = \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma u \, dx, \\ \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma v \rangle_\Gamma \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma v \, dx \quad \forall v \in K. \end{cases}$$

We close this section by showing, that the hybrid formulation above is equivalent to the previous weak formulations in Problem 3.2 in order to prove that it is indeed a valid formulation of the Signorini problem.

Proposition 3.7 (Equivalence of Hybrid and Weak Formulation). *Every solution $u \in K$ to Problem 3.2 is also a solution to Problem 3.4 and vice versa.*

Proof. Let $u \in K$ solve Problem 3.2, i.e. it holds

$$a(u, v - u) \geq \ell(v - u) \quad \forall v \in K. \quad (3.17)$$

We take a test function $\varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$. Then $\gamma\varphi = 0$ on Γ and $u \pm t\varphi \in K$ for all $t > 0$. Testing $v := u \pm t\varphi$ in (3.17) yields

$$a(u, \pm t\varphi) \geq \ell(\pm t\varphi) \quad \implies \quad \begin{cases} a(u, \varphi) \geq \ell(\varphi), \\ a(u, \varphi) \leq \ell(\varphi), \end{cases} \quad \implies \quad a(u, \varphi) = \ell(\varphi). \quad (3.18)$$

for all $\varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$. Furthermore since $\gamma\varphi = 0$, we have

$$\int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma\varphi \, ds = 0 \quad \implies \quad \ell(\varphi) = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot \varphi \, dx$$

and with the symmetry $\sigma(u)^\top = \sigma(u)$,

$$a(u, \varphi) = \int_{\Omega} \sigma(u) : \varepsilon(\varphi) \, dx = \int_{\Omega} \sigma(u) : \nabla \varphi \, dx.$$

Hence, for all $\varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, we obtain that (3.18) reads

$$\int_{\Omega} \sigma(u) : \nabla \varphi \, dx = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot \varphi \, dx.$$

Interpreting $\sigma(u)$ and f as regular distributions, and using the distributional divergence of matrix-valued distributions, this is equivalent to

$$\langle -\operatorname{div} \sigma(u), \varphi \rangle = \langle f, \varphi \rangle \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

Therefore,

$$-\operatorname{div} \sigma(u) = f \quad \text{in } \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

If, in addition, $\sigma(u) \in H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$, then $\operatorname{div} \sigma(u) \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ and both sides are regular distributions. By injectivity of the embedding $\mathcal{T} : L^1_{\operatorname{loc}}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d) \rightarrow \mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$, it follows that

$$-\operatorname{div} \sigma(u) = f \quad \text{a.e. in } \Omega. \quad (3.19)$$

This is the first condition in Problem 3.4. Now let $v \in K$ be arbitrary and set $w := v - u$. Then by (3.16) and (3.19) we have

$$a(u, w) = - \int_{\Omega} \operatorname{div} \sigma(u) \cdot w \, dx + \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma w \rangle_\Gamma = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot w \, dx + \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma w \rangle_\Gamma. \quad (3.20)$$

On the other hand, by (3.17) we have

$$a(u, w) \geq \ell(w) = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot w \, dx + \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma w \, ds$$

which by subtracting $\langle f, w \rangle$ yields

$$\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma w \rangle_{\Gamma} \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma w \, ds \quad \forall w \in K.$$

This is the second condition in Problem 3.4. By Proposition 3.5 the condition (3.17) implies $a(u, u) = \ell(u)$ and $a(u, v) \geq \ell(v)$ for all $v \in K$. Again, with (3.16) and (3.19), we have

$$a(u, u) = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot u \, dx + \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma u \rangle_{\Gamma} \quad \text{and} \quad \ell(u) = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot u \, dx + \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma u \, ds$$

and thus by $a(u, u) = \ell(u)$ and subtracting $\langle f, u \rangle$,

$$\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma u \rangle_{\Gamma} = \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma u \, ds.$$

This is the third condition in Problem 3.4. Now we assume that $u \in K$ solves Problem 3.4. Let $v \in K$ be arbitrary and $w := v - u$. Subtracting the boundary conditions in Problem 3.4 yields

$$\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma w \rangle_{\Gamma} = \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma v \rangle_{\Gamma} - \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma u \rangle_{\Gamma} \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot (\gamma v - \gamma u) \, ds = \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma w \, ds.$$

With (3.20) it holds

$$a(v, w) = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot w \, dx + \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma w \rangle_{\Gamma} \geq \int_{\Omega} f \cdot w \, dx + \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma w \, ds = \ell(w) = \ell(v - u).$$

This is exactly Problem 3.2. ■

3.3.3 Normal/Tangential Splitting and Contact Trace Spaces

3.3.4 KKT Contact Conditions

3.3.5 Classical Strong Form under Additional Regularity

3.4 Mixed Formulation

3.4.1 Mixed Weak Formulation as a Saddlepoint Problem

3.4.2 Well-posedness and inf-sup condition

4 Outlook

A References

- [1] Franz Chouly, Patrick Hild, and Yves Renard. *Finite Element Approximation of Contact and Friction in Elasticity*, volume 48 of *Advances in Continuum Mechanics*. Springer International Publishing, 2023.

B List of Figures

- 1 2D example of Signorini’s problem before (left) and after displacement (right). . 13